

Fundamental Theorem of Arithmetic in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$

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Contents

Contents	1
1 Introduction	1
2 History	1
3 Integers	2
4 Rationals	2
5 The Ring $\mathbb{Q}[x]$	3
5.1 Basic Arithmetic	5
5.2 Divisibility	7
6 The Division Algorithm in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$	7
7 Euclid's Algorithm	9
8 Conclusion	10

1. Introduction

2. History

Historical background is often nice.

Definition 1. Define **summation**, or $\sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i$ for $n \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ and $n \geq i_0$ as follows:

$$\sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} = a_{i_0} \quad \sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i = a_n + \sum_{i=i_0}^{n-1} a_i$$

Definition 2. Define **product**, or $\prod_{i=i_0}^n a_i$ for $n \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ and $n \geq i_0$ as follows:

$$\prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0} = a_{i_0} \quad \prod_{i=i_0}^n a_i = a_n \cdot \prod_{i=i_0}^{n-1} a_i$$

3. Integers

Lemma 1 (NIBZO). *There is no integer strictly between 0 and 1. Equivalently, if $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ and*

$$0 < n < 1,$$

then such an n cannot exist.

Proof. Suppose, for contradiction, that there is an integer strictly between 0 and 1. Put

$$S = \{n \in \mathbb{Z} : 0 < n < 1\}.$$

Then S is nonempty and $S \subseteq \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$. By the well-ordering principle, S has a least element. Call it m .

Since $0 < m$, multiplicative closure of positive integers gives $0 < m^2$. Since $m < 1$ and $m > 0$, multiplying the inequality $m < 1$ by the positive integer m gives

$$m^2 < m.$$

Thus m^2 is also an integer satisfying

$$0 < m^2 < m < 1.$$

So $m^2 \in S$, but $m^2 < m$. This contradicts the choice of m as the least element of S . Therefore S is empty. $\square$

4. Rationals

Lemma 2 (No zero divisors in $\mathbb{Q}$). *If $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$ and $ab = 0$, then $a = 0$ or $b = 0$.*

Proof. Suppose $ab = 0$. If $a = 0$, there is nothing to prove. Now assume $a \neq 0$. Then a^{-1} exists in $\mathbb{Q}$. Multiplying both sides of $ab = 0$ by a^{-1} gives

$$a^{-1}(ab) = a^{-1} \cdot 0.$$

By associativity, the left side is

$$(a^{-1}a)b = 1b = b.$$

Also $a^{-1} \cdot 0 = 0$: indeed,

$$a^{-1} \cdot 0 = a^{-1}(0 + 0) = a^{-1} \cdot 0 + a^{-1} \cdot 0,$$

and adding the additive inverse of $a^{-1} \cdot 0$ to both sides gives $a^{-1} \cdot 0 = 0$. Hence $b = 0$. Therefore $a = 0$ or $b = 0$. $\square$

5. The Ring $\mathbb{Q}[x]$

Definition 3 (The polynomial ring $\mathbb{Q}[x]$). We define a polynomial $f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ with degree n if it can be written as

$$f(x) = \sum_0^n a_i x^i$$

where $n \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$ and each coefficient a_i lies in $\mathbb{Q}$ and $a_n \neq 0$.

Theorem 3 ($\mathbb{Q}[x]$ is a commutative ring.).

Proof. We check the ring conditions. Addition stays inside $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ because each coefficient $a_i + b_i$ is rational. Multiplication also stays inside $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ because each coefficient c_k is built from finitely many sums and products of rational numbers.

The zero polynomial is the additive identity because adding zero to every coefficient changes nothing. The polynomial $-f(x)$ is the additive inverse of $f(x)$ because each coefficient becomes $a_i + (-a_i) = 0$. The constant polynomial 1 is the multiplicative identity because multiplying by 1 leaves the coefficients unchanged.

The associative and commutative laws come from the same laws in $\mathbb{Q}$, coefficient by coefficient. For instance, addition is associative because

$$(a_k + b_k) + c_k = a_k + (b_k + c_k)$$

for each coefficient. The multiplication laws and distributivity are checked in the same way from the rational-number laws.

Finally, the zero polynomial has constant coefficient 0, while the constant polynomial 1 has constant coefficient 1. Since $0 \neq 1$ in $\mathbb{Q}$, have $0_{\mathbb{Q}[x]} \neq 1_{\mathbb{Q}[x]}$. $\square$

Definition 4. For $f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, let the **norm**, or $\|f(x)\|$ be equal to

$$\|f(x)\| = 2^{\deg f(x)}$$

with the following properties:

- $\|f(x)\| \cdot \|g(x)\| = \|f(x)g(x)\|$

Proof. By Multiplied Sums, if $f(x) = \sum_{i=0}^n a_i x^i$ and $g(x) = \sum_{j=0}^m b_j x^j$, with n and m the degrees of f and g respectively, then

$$f(x)g(x) = \sum_{i=0}^n \sum_{j=0}^m a_i b_j x^i x^j = \sum_{i=0}^n \sum_{j=0}^m a_i b_j x^{i+j}$$

Notice that to find the degree of $f(x)g(x)$, we take the maximum value of $i+j$ which is their respective maximums, $n+m$, so:

$$\|f(x)g(x)\| = 2^{n+m} = 2^n 2^m = \|f(x)\| \|g(x)\|$$

□

- For any $c(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]^\times$, $\|c(x)\| = 1$.

Proof. Since $\deg c(x) = 0$, $\|c(x)\| = 2^0 = 1$.

□

Lemma 4 (Multiplication). *For multiplication, if*

$$f(x) = a_0 + a_1 x + \cdots + a_m x^m \quad \text{and} \quad g(x) = b_0 + b_1 x + \cdots + b_n x^n,$$

then

$$f(x)g(x) = c_0 + c_1 x + \cdots + c_{m+n} x^{m+n},$$

where each coefficient c_k is found by adding all products $a_i b_j$ for which the exponents satisfy $i+j = k$. For example,

$$c_0 = a_0 b_0, \quad c_1 = a_0 b_1 + a_1 b_0, \quad c_{m+n} = a_m b_n.$$

Definition 5 (Zero, one, and negatives). The zero element of $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ is the polynomial $0_{Qx} = 0$. Define the degree of 0_{Qx} to be $-\infty$. The one element of $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ is the constant polynomial

$$1_{\mathbb{Q}[x]} = 1$$

If

$$f(x) = \sum_{i=0}^n a_i x^i$$

then

$$-f(x) = \sum_0^n -a_i x^i$$

Theorem 5 ($\mathbb{Q}[x]$ has no zero divisors). *If $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ and*

$$f(x)g(x) = 0,$$

then $f(x) = 0$ or $g(x) = 0$.

Proof. Suppose $f \neq 0$ and $g \neq 0$. Then

$$\deg(fg) = \deg(f) + \deg(g) \geq 0,$$

so fg is nonzero. This contradicts $fg = 0$. Hence at least one of f and g must be zero. $\square$

Corollary 6 (Cancellation). *If $h(x) \neq 0$ and*

$$h(x)f(x) = h(x)g(x),$$

then $f(x) = g(x)$.

Proof. Subtract the right side from the left:

$$h(f - g) = 0.$$

Since $h \neq 0$ and $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ has no zero divisors, we must have $f - g = 0$. Thus $f = g$. $\square$

5.1. Basic Arithmetic

Lemma 7 (Uniqueness of zero and one). *The additive identity and multiplicative identity in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ are unique. In particular, if $f(x) + z(x) = f(x)$ for every $f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, then $z(x) = 0$. Similarly, if $f(x)u(x) = f(x)$ for every $f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, then $u(x) = 1$.*

Proof. Suppose z acts like an additive identity for f , so $f + z = f$. Add $-f$ to both sides:

$$(-f) + (f + z) = (-f) + f.$$

By associativity and the definition of additive inverse, this becomes

$$0 + z = 0.$$

Since 0 is the additive identity, $z = 0$.

Now suppose u acts like a multiplicative identity for every polynomial. Test this on the constant polynomial 1:

$$1 \cdot u = 1.$$

But $1 \cdot u = u$. Hence $u = 1$. □

Lemma 8 (Uniqueness of additive inverses). *If $u(x)$ and $v(x)$ are both additive inverses of $f(x)$, then $u(x) = v(x)$.*

Proof. Assume

$$f + u = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad f + v = 0.$$

Then $f + u = f + v$. Add $-f$ to both sides:

$$(-f) + (f + u) = (-f) + (f + v).$$

By associativity,

$$((-f) + f) + u = ((-f) + f) + v.$$

Thus

$$0 + u = 0 + v,$$

so $u = v$. □

Lemma 9 (Zero and negatives). *For all $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$,*

$$f(x) \cdot 0 = 0, \quad -(-f(x)) = f(x), \quad (-f(x))(-g(x)) = f(x)g(x).$$

Proof. First,

$$f \cdot 0 = f(0 + 0) = f \cdot 0 + f \cdot 0.$$

Adding the additive inverse of $f \cdot 0$ to both sides gives $f \cdot 0 = 0$.

Next, since

$$(-f) + f = 0,$$

the polynomial f is an additive inverse of $-f$. By uniqueness of additive inverses,

$$-(-f) = f.$$

For the product of negatives, first observe that

$$fg + (-f)g = (f + (-f))g = 0 \cdot g = 0.$$

Therefore $(-f)g = -(fg)$. Applying this with g replaced by $-g$ gives

$$(-f)(-g) = -(f(-g)).$$

Also,

$$fg + f(-g) = f(g + (-g)) = f \cdot 0 = 0,$$

so $f(-g) = -(fg)$. Hence

$$(-f)(-g) = -(-(fg)) = fg.$$

□

5.2. Divisibility

Definition 6 (Divisibility). For $a(x), b(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, we say $a(x)$ divides $b(x)$, written

$$a(x) \mid b(x),$$

if there exists $q(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ such that

$$b(x) = a(x)q(x).$$

6. The Division Algorithm in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$

For $\mathbb{Q}[x]$, the norm plays the role that size plays in integer division. Since norms of nonzero polynomials are positive integers, we can use the well-ordering principle to pick a remainder of smallest norm.

Theorem 10 (Division algorithm in $\mathbb{Q}[x]$). *Let $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ with $g(x) \neq 0$. Then there exist unique polynomials $q(x), r(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ such that*

$$f(x) = q(x)g(x) + r(x),$$

where either

$$r(x) = 0$$

or

$$\|r(x)\| < \|g(x)\|.$$

Proof. Existence. Look at all possible remainders after subtracting multiples of g from f :

$$S = \{ f(x) - q(x)g(x) : q(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x] \}.$$

If $0 \in S$, then $f = qg$ for some q , so

$$f = qg + 0,$$

and the result holds with $r = 0$.

Now suppose $0 \notin S$. Then every element of S is nonzero, so each element has a norm in $\mathbb{Z}^+$. Define

$$D = \{ \|s(x)\| : s(x) \in S \} \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^+.$$

The set D is nonempty because $f - 0g = f$ lies in S . By the well-ordering principle, D has a smallest element. Choose $r \in S$ with minimum norm. Since $r \in S$, there exists $q \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ such that

$$r = f - qg.$$

Equivalently,

$$f = qg + r.$$

It remains to show that $\|r(x)\| < \|g(x)\|$. Suppose instead that

$$\|r(x)\| \geq \|g(x)\|.$$

Write

$$r(x) = a_m x^m + \cdots \quad \text{and} \quad g(x) = b_n x^n + \cdots,$$

where $a_m, b_n \neq 0$, $m = \deg(r)$, and $n = \deg(g)$. Since $\|r(x)\| \geq \|g(x)\|$ means $2^m \geq 2^n$, we get $m \geq n$. Since $b_n \neq 0$ and $b_n \in \mathbb{Q}$, the rational number a_m/b_n exists. Define

$$r^*(x) = r(x) - \frac{a_m}{b_n} x^{m-n} g(x).$$

The second term has leading term $a_m x^m$, so the leading term of r cancels. Thus either $r^* = 0$ or

$$\|r^*(x)\| < \|r(x)\|.$$

Also,

$$\begin{aligned} r^* &= f - qg - \frac{a_m}{b_n} x^{m-n} g \\ &= f - \left(q + \frac{a_m}{b_n} x^{m-n} \right) g. \end{aligned}$$

Therefore $r^* \in S$. If $r^* = 0$, then $0 \in S$, which is not the case we are in. If $r^* \neq 0$, then r^* is in S and has smaller norm than r , contradicting how we chose r . Therefore our assumption was false, and

$$\|r(x)\| < \|g(x)\|.$$

Uniqueness. Suppose

$$f = q_1g + r_1 = q_2g + r_2,$$

where r_1 and r_2 are both either zero or have norm less than $\|g(x)\|$. Subtracting gives

$$g(q_1 - q_2) = r_2 - r_1.$$

Assume $q_1 \neq q_2$. Then $q_1 - q_2 \neq 0$, and since $\mathbb{Q}[x]$ has no zero divisors,

$$g(q_1 - q_2) \neq 0.$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned} \|g(x)(q_1(x) - q_2(x))\| &= 2^{\deg(g(q_1 - q_2))} \\ &= 2^{\deg(g) + \deg(q_1 - q_2)} \\ &= \|g(x)\| \cdot \|q_1(x) - q_2(x)\| \\ &\geq \|g(x)\|. \end{aligned}$$

But $r_2 - r_1$ is either zero or has norm strictly less than $\|g(x)\|$, since each of r_1 and r_2 is either zero or has norm less than $\|g(x)\|$, so their degrees are both less than $\deg(g)$ when they are nonzero. This is impossible. Therefore $q_1 = q_2$. Substituting back gives $r_1 = r_2$. $\square$

7. Euclid's Algorithm

Definition 7. Define **Euclids Algorithm** on $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ to produce $r, q \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$ such that

$$f = q_1g + r_1 \quad g = q_2r_1 + r_2 \quad r_{n-2} = q_nr_{n-1} + r_n$$

Lemma 11. For any $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, the Euclidean Algorithm generates an $n \in \mathbb{Z}^+$ such that $r_n = 0$.

Proof. Let $S = \{f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x] \mid \exists g(x) \text{ s.t. } r_i \neq 0 \forall i \in \mathbb{Z}\}$. For the sake of contradiction, S is not empty. By the well-ordering principle, there exists a least element l . Performing Euclid's Algorithm on (l, g) , we have:

$$\begin{aligned} g &= q_1 * l + r_1 \\ l &= q_2r_1 + r_2 \end{aligned}$$

If (g, l) does not reach 0, (l, r_1) will also not reach 0, as they generate the same values. Thus, $r_1 \in S$, but $r_1 < l$ by the division algorithm, which is a contradiction. Thus, S must be empty. $\square$

Lemma 12. For any $f(x), g(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x]$, if the Euclidean Algorithm generates $r_n = 0$, $r_{n-1} = \gcd(f, g)$.

Proof. Let $S = \{f(x) \in \mathbb{Q}[x] \mid \exists g(x) \text{ s.t. } r_{n-1} \neq \gcd(f, g)\}$. For the sake of contradiction, S is not empty. By the well-ordering principle, there exists a least element l . Performing Euclid's Algorithm on (l, g) , we have:

$$g = q_1 * l + r_1$$

If $\gcd(g, l) = d$, $d \mid g$ and $d \mid l$. Since $b > l$, $\gcd(l, r_1)$ remains d . However, the Euclidean Algorithm on (r_1, l) generates the same values as (b, l) . Thus, $r_1 \in S$, but $r_1 < l$ by the division algorithm, which is a contradiction. Thus, S must be empty. $\square$

8. Conclusion

Conclude with the big ideas!

Appendix A: Summation and Product Lemmas

Lemma 13. $\sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^n b_i = \sum_{i=i_0}^n (a_i + b_i)$

Proof. Note that

$$\sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} b_i = a_{i_0} + b_{i_0} = \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} (a_i + b_i)$$

Let $S = \left\{ k \in \mathbb{Z}^+ \mid \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} b_i \neq \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} (a_i + b_i) \right\}$. For the sake of contradiction, S is not empty.

As $S \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^+$, by the Well-Ordering Principle, there exists a least element $l \in S$.

If $k = 1$:

$$\sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} b_i = a_{i_0+1} + a_{i_0} + b_{i_0+1} + b_{i_0} = (a_{i_0+1} + b_{i_0+1}) + (a_{i_0} + b_{i_0}) = \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} (a_i + b_i)$$

Thus, $1 \notin S$ and so $l > 1$ by NIBZO. Since $l - 1 \in \mathbb{Z}$ yet $l - 1 \notin S$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i &= \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} (a_i + b_i) \\ a_l + b_l + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i &= a_l + b_l + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} (a_i + b_i) \\ a_l + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i + b_l + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i &= (a_l + b_l) + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} (a_i + b_i) \\ \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} a_i + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} b_i &= \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} (a_i + b_i) \end{aligned}$$

However, since $l \in S$, this is a contradiction. Thus, S must be empty. $\square$

Lemma 14. *Sum Constants:* $\sum_{i=i_0}^n ca_i = c \sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i$

Proof. Note that

$$\sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} ca_i = ca_{i_0} = c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0} a_i$$

and that

$$\sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} ca_i = ca_{i_0} + ca_{i_0+1} = c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} a_i$$

Let $S = \left\{ k \in \mathbb{Z}^+ \mid \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} ca_i \neq c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} a_i \right\}$. For the sake of contradiction, S is not empty. As $S \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^+$, by the well-ordering principle, there exists a least element $l \in S$. Since $1 \notin S$, $l > 1$ by NIBZO. As $l - 1 \in \mathbb{Z}$ yet $l - 1 \notin S$,

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} ca_i &= c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i \\ ca_l + \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} ca_i &= ca_l + c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i \\ \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} ca_i &= c \sum_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} a_i \end{aligned}$$

However, since $l \in S$, this is a contradiction. Thus, S must be empty. $\square$

Lemma 15. *Multiplied Sums:* $\sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i \cdot \sum_{j=j_0}^m b_j = \sum_{i=i_0}^n \sum_{j=j_0}^m (a_i b_j)$

Proof. By Sum Constants, we know that

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i \cdot \sum_{j=j_0}^m b_j &= \sum_{i=i_0}^n (a_i \cdot \sum_{j=j_0}^m b_j) \\ \sum_{i=i_0}^n a_i \cdot \sum_{j=j_0}^m b_j &= \sum_{i=i_0}^n (\sum_{j=j_0}^m a_i b_j) \end{aligned}$$

□

Lemma 16. $\prod_{i=i_0}^n a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^n b_i = \prod_{i=i_0}^n a_i b_i$

Proof. Note that

$$\prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0} b_i = a_{i_0} b_{i_0} = \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0} a_i b_i$$

Let $S = \left\{ k \in \mathbb{Z}^+ \mid \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} b_i \neq \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+k} a_i b_i \right\}$. For the sake of contradiction, S is not empty. As $S \subseteq \mathbb{Z}^+$, by the Well-Ordering Principle, there exists a least element $l \in S$.

If $k = 1$:

$$\prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} b_i = a_{i_0+1} a_{i_0} \cdot b_{i_0+1} b_{i_0} = (a_{i_0+1} b_{i_0+1})(a_{i_0} b_{i_0}) = \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+1} a_i b_i$$

Thus, $1 \notin S$ and so $l > 1$ by NIBZO. Since $l-1 \in \mathbb{Z}$ yet $l-1 \notin S$,

$$\begin{aligned} \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i &= \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i b_i \\ a_l b_l \cdot \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i &= a_l b_l \cdot \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i b_i \\ (a_l \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i) \cdot (b_l \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} b_i) &= (a_l b_l) \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l-1} a_i b_i \\ \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} a_i \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} b_i &= \prod_{i=i_0}^{i_0+l} a_i b_i \end{aligned}$$

However, since $l \in S$, this is a contradiction. Thus, S must be empty. □